

ANALYSIS

Trump reprises his dark political theater

State of Union speech attacks Democrats as he frames narrative ahead of midterms.

By Kevin Rector

Capitalizing on a grand stage Tuesday night, President Trump delivered a State of the Union speech laced with political broadsides blaming Democrats for the nation's problems, including on immigration and the economy, and heaping praise on himself and his administration for ushering in "a turnaround for the ages."

He did not mention that after a year of his holding the White House and his party controlling both chambers of Congress, many Americans remain displeased and financially frustrated, with increasing numbers blaming Trump, according to polling.

The speech was heavy on partisan attacks, but light on any real acknowledgment of — or proposed path out of — the mounting political tensions that are roiling the nation under his leadership and threatening his party's chances of retaining power in the upcoming midterms.

"President Trump's State of the Union address was deeply disconnected from the lived reality of most Americans and profoundly insulting to the immigrant communities who strengthen and sustain this country every day," Angelica Salas, executive director of the Co-

[See Trump, A7]

Digging in on border policies

President calls his immigration actions a success despite their rising unpopularity.

By Andrea Castillo

WASHINGTON — To defend an increasingly unpopular immigration crack-down during his State of the Union speech, President Trump highlighted the victims of crimes perpetrated by undocumented immigrants.

But as Democrats pointed out, the president's lengthy speech made no reference to Renee Nicole Good and Alex Pretti, U.S. citizens in Minneapolis who were shot and killed by immigration agents.

Recent polls show public approval of Trump's immigration policies has fallen to record lows since he returned to the White House. One poll, released Feb. 17 by Reuters and the market research firm Ipsos, showed just 38% of respondents felt Trump was doing a good job on immigration.

Another poll, published last month by Fox News, showed 59% of voters say Immigration and Customs Enforcement is "too aggressive."

"As President Trump brags about his immigration enforcement at tonight's State of the Union, I can think only of Renee Nicole Good, Alex Pretti and the three dozen people who have died in ICE custody since Trump took office," Rep.

[See Immigration, A7]



GARY CORONADO For The Times



WILLIAM LIANG Associated Press

LAUSD Supt. Alberto Carvalho, top, backed an AI tool named "Ed" for students that was built by a firm called AllHere. Above, the media outside Carvalho's home.

OpenAI, Anthropic battle for dominance

By Queenie Wong

As more than 100 million people watched the Super Bowl, the battle for the future of artificial intelligence spilled out into a massive public arena.

In a series of viral commercials, AI upstart startup Anthropic broadcast to football fans that they should avoid AI with ads. The commercial obviously was targeting OpenAI, which plans to add ads to ChatGPT. Anthropic's bot, Claude, never will have ads, it says.

In one of the Super Bowl slots, a short man asks a representation of an AI assistant how to get six-pack abs. The super supportive AI trainer says he has a workout plan for the man before abruptly pivoting to a pitch for height-increasing insoles.

Sam Altman, co-founder and chief executive of OpenAI, fired back on social media, calling the ads "clearly dishonest."

The public spat between the dueling San Francisco companies showcased an intense rivalry between OpenAI and Anthropic as they go head-to-head in a battle that could shape the technology's future. While both companies are still very young, their grappling could emerge as the next big clash between brands like

IBM vs. Apple, Coke vs. Pepsi and McDonald's vs. Burger King.

While there are other AI behemoths — including Google, Meta, Microsoft, Amazon and others — OpenAI's tension with Anthropic is telling because it stems from their shared origins and different philosophies.

OpenAI historically has favored quick, free, public releases of its latest AI models, such as ChatGPT. It believes that feedback from many users helps improve its models and make them safer.

Anthropic, co-founded by Dario Amodei, who left OpenAI in part because of its direction, says it is taking a more cautious approach. It says it is focusing on how to build AI products slowly and safely. It tries to control who gets the latest tech before unleashing it on the masses.

That difference in stances — OpenAI's need for speed versus Anthropic's stress on safety — has helped trigger the tension. Experts say OpenAI seems more likely to push boundaries with broad public access, while Anthropic initially prefers incremental steps through partnerships. Each wants

[See AI, A10]

Off-roaders lose to tortoise

Popular trails in parts of Mojave have been closed to protect the imperiled desert animal's habitat

By Alex Wigglesworth



ETHAN SWOPE For The Times

OFF-ROAD vehicles like this one in Johnson Valley have posed a threat to the California desert tortoise.

MOJAVE DESERT — The desert tortoise, a once-resilient reptile, is a keystone species in the Mojave Desert, where other animals' survival depends on the burrows it digs.

But it is imperiled in California thanks in part to an unusual enemy: off-road vehicles that race through thousands of miles of trails — official and unofficial — that crisscross millions of acres of tortoise habitat.

Federal Judge Susan Illston recently ordered the Bureau of Land Management to shut down 2,000 miles of these trails, saying the off-road vehicles — technically called "off-highway vehicles" or "OHVs" — are "a significant ongoing cause of harm" to the tortoise population. Since the 1970s, tortoise populations have fallen by 96% in some plots monitored by biologist Kristin Berry of the U.S. Geological Survey.

Biologist Ed LaRue, who has taken up the cause of the animals, watched the other day as a lifted pickup truck with a large American flag and a utility task vehicle raced down a trail in the Mojave, sending up plumes of

[See Tortoise, A6]

FBI probes L.A. schools chief's ties to an AI firm

Company had created a chatbot for district. Carvalho's home and office are searched.

By Brittny Mejia, Richard Winton, Ruben Vives and Howard Blume

Federal authorities raided the home and office of Los Angeles Unified School District Supt. Alberto Carvalho on Wednesday morning in what appears to be a probe related to a company that developed an AI chatbot for the nation's second-largest school system.

Authorities have not provided any details about the investigation. But one source with knowledge of the matter said it involved AllHere, a failed AI company whose founder was charged with fraud in 2024.

Along with Carvalho's San Pedro home and office at LAUSD headquarters in downtown Los Angeles, the FBI provided an address in Florida that was searched Wednesday morning. Public records show that property is linked to an individual who worked with AllHere.

Law enforcement sources, who requested anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly, told The Times that the federal investigation specifically involves Carvalho, who has served as LAUSD superintendent since February 2022.

FBI agents searched a

residence in Southwest Ranches, a town in Broward County, Fla., in connection with the investigation, according to an FBI spokesman in Miami.

According to public record databases, Debra Kerr, a salesperson whose clients included AllHere, is listed as the owner of the Florida home. Neither the FBI nor confidential sources identified Kerr on Wednesday as a target of the investigation. Attempts to contact Kerr were unsuccessful.

Kerr, a successful consultant to companies seeking work with school districts, has long ties to Carvalho, going back to his time as superintendent in Miami. She worked as a consultant to AllHere and has claimed in court documents that the company owes her \$630,000.

The 74, an education news site, previously reported that Kerr said AllHere never paid her a commission owed for work closing the AllHere deal in Los Angeles. The outlet also reported that Kerr's son, Richard, is a former AllHere account executive who told the 74 he pitched the company to L.A. school leaders.

The FBI declined to share more information, citing the fact that the affidavits have been sealed by the court. Sources familiar with the probe said that the focus was Carvalho as opposed to LAUSD, and that it would fall under the broad category of financial issues.

Ciaran McEvoy, a spokesperson for the U.S. attorney in Los Angeles, said

[See Carvalho, A5]

Caltech scientist's slaying is mystery

Man accused of killing astrophysicist in desert town had prior run-ins with the law.

By Salvador Hernandez

Situated deep in the Mojave desert, Llano is secluded — and that's always been one of its biggest selling points.

More than a century ago, the hamlet was home to a storied socialist cooperative that historians described as one of America's most significant Utopian societies. The Llano Del Rio Cooperative Colony is long gone, but its stone remains are perhaps the biggest attraction in a place marked by vast open spaces dotted with homes on sprawling lots.

One of those homes was Carl Grillmair's. To him, the remoteness of Llano was its prime attraction. Grillmair, 67, was a Caltech astrophysicist, and colleagues said he was drawn there because, unobstructed by city lights, the desert offered clear views of the cosmos at night.

Freddy Snyder was another member of the community, a married 29-year-old father of two living with his mother just two miles from Grillmair.

On Feb. 16, authorities allege, their lives collided on Grillmair's front porch when



IPAC/Caltech

CARL GRILLMAIR, a Caltech astrophysicist, was fatally shot at his Antelope Valley home.

Snyder arrived at the home and fatally shot the astrophysicist.

The killing shocked the Caltech community, where Grillmair was a beloved researcher, and the sparsely populated enclave.

"Out in the country, we don't deal with those kinds of issues," said one Llano resident who recalled his own run-in with Snyder but asked not to be identified for fear for his safety. "We got away from all those, or at least we thought."

Now, Los Angeles County Sheriff's Department detectives are trying to unravel what sparked the deadly shooting.

Officials and court documents indicate that weeks earlier, Snyder had had a run-in with Grillmair.

On Dec. 20, Lt. Michael Modica of the Los Angeles

[See Slaying, A5]

Clintons will testify on Epstein ties

Former president and secretary of State will speak in the inquiry on convicted sex offender. **NATION, A4**

Molester's parole sparks outrage

Decision renews calls to reform the state's elderly release program. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Sunny and warm.
L.A. Basin: 82/60. **B6**

Markets **A10**
Opinion Voices **A12**

Awards show may be a no-go

Writers Guild of America West threatens to pull gala amid strike by staff union. **BUSINESS, A9**

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